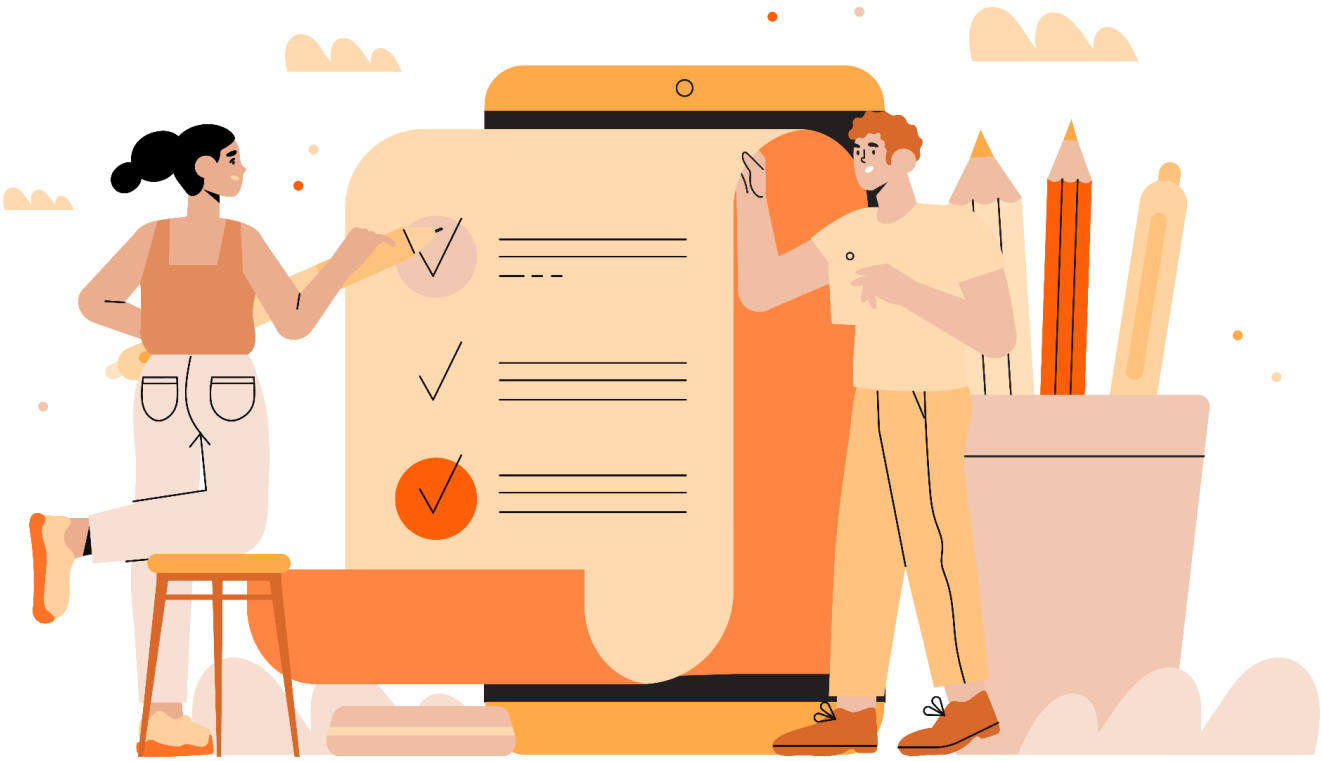
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Navigating The Recession: a Checklist for Engineering Leaders

A checklist to help engineering leaders navigate the uncertainties of the recession and drive positive business impact.



In the face of a looming recession, engineering leaders and the products they build are, **now more than ever**, crucial to the success of tech companies

To help these leaders navigate the challenges ahead, we've created a checklist covering four key areas: **Personal, Organizational, People, and Technical.**

This checklist is filled with practical advice to help engineering leaders work on themselves as leaders, reflect on their organizational goals and culture, create a supportive team environment, and focus on the technical tools and metrics necessary for optimal performance.

By following this checklist, engineering leaders can **feel more confident and better equipped to lead their teams through the uncertainties of the recession** and, hopefully, continue to have a positive impact on their organizations.

Organization

As an engineering leader, a recession presents an opportunity to refocus and prioritize.

It is the perfect time to hone your skills and prepare your org for the future, making sure you survive and outcompete during tough times, and scale as soon as things improve.

During this period, you can expect changes to your teams. However, with your expertise and leadership, you'll be able to navigate these challenges with confidence and come out stronger on the other side. Here's how.



- [ ] **Build high-performance teams**

  Maybe your budget was cut, and/or you had to let go of some people. Business pressure will increase, and you will need to do more with less. Your only solution here is to build high-performance teams.

  Read more:

  5 Steps for Building High-Performance Teams

  Continuous Improvement for High-Performing Teams

- [ ] **Run great retrospectives**

  Ensure high-quality retrospectives so you can learn and iterate quickly. Be hard on what can be improved and leverage metrics to back your intuitions.

  Read more:

  Inside the Pixar Braintrust

  Parabol: Agile Meeting Tools for High-Performing Teams

- [ ] **Create a proper incident response process**

  Incidents can be stressful, especially when they impact your customers. Build an incident response process that is focused on fixing issues quickly.

  Read more:

  The Complete Guide to Incident Response

- [ ] **Create a proper on-call process**

  On-calls can be hard on a team, especially in crisis times. Build an on-call rotation system that's fair.

Read more:

PagerDuty

Crafting Sustainable On-Call Rotations

Document everything

Sure, everyone hates writing documentation. But whether it's a product, code, or internal process; documentation is going to be critical. There's just no way around it; your role is enabling it.

Read more:

GitBook

Software Documentation Types and Best Practices

GitLab's Engineering Handbook

Have a system to track work and progress

Without entering into any philosophical war between Scrum, Kanban, Agile, etc., it's essential to track ideas, work, bugs, and more in a centralized place. Adopt the system that works for you and your stage. Your system of record and process should evolve as you mature.

Read more:

Linear

Shortcut

And, of course, Jira 🙈

Manage team dependencies

You can't afford to have team dependencies that hinder your teams' productivity. Make sure your teams are as autonomous as possible.

Read more:

Team Topologies: Organizing Business and Technology Teams for Fast Flow

5 Principles for Forming Autonomous Software Engineering Teams

Formalize your org and responsibilities

Formalizing responsibilities is a necessary evil that will always break as you scale your team. But that's OK.

Read more:

The Dashlane Triple Track: Looking for the Right Organization

Cascade information through the org

A healthy two-way cascading of information will be critical in these times. You will need to ensure your EMs and TLs are regularly and formally cascading information through the org. Make sure you communicate important points in your 1–1s.

Read more:

What is an All-Hands Meeting and Why Should You Start Having One?

Cascade: Information Change Communications

Define an engineering strategy

Your engineering will evolve rapidly during a recession. But not spending enough time formalizing it to ensure that your team and the rest of the company are aligned is going to cost you down the line. Define a strategy, measure your progress and iterate often.

Read more:

Engineering Strategies

Announce org changes and layoffs

Announcing org changes or layoffs is not an easy task. Make sure you prepare the what and the how properly.

Read more:

Org Change and the First 90 Days in a New Role

Preparing to Announce Layoffs in a Virtual Meeting

How to Write a Speech to Announce Layoffs

Make team adjustments

Yes, during a recession, your team is going to evolve. You might not be able to hire the people you need and even have to do layoffs. Not readjusting your teams and org structure based on this new reality will slow you down. Keep your org agile as new changes might happen.

Read more:

How to Evolve an Engineering Organization

Reorgs Happen: Here's How to Deal with Them

Sizing Engineering Teams

Measure what matters

Once your team is of a certain size, you're unlikely to be aware of everything that is happening. To be able to improve, you will need to measure and track what matters to your context. In a recession, velocity (PR Cycle Time) and output (PRs deployed) are probably what matters most.

Read more:

9 Most Important Software Engineering Metrics to Track

How Metrics Impact Different Engineering Leaders & Their Teams

Measuring Engineering Organizations

Adapting During Recession: Strategies for Engineering Leaders

Have your team obsess about customers

Retaining and expanding customers is probably the most efficient way to make revenue in a recession. Make sure your engineers are building a customer mindset.

Read more:

Customer Affinity

How to Build a Product Delivery Organization: Interview with Jonathan Nolen

- [ ]

Improve your delivery estimates

The pressure to deliver features to market and your ability to deliver them on time is critical in a recession. Estimates aren't a science but a necessary evil for the business. Becoming more predictable in your delivery just as you're improving your team's velocity will make you successful.

Read more:

Estimating a Software Deadline Is Really Hard — Let's Talk About Why

- [ ]

Fix your organizational debt

Recessions and team changes are a good forcing function to think about your current organizational debt and fix it. Steve Blank said "Organizational Debt is like Technical debt – but worse"

Read more:

Refactor Your Organisation

Organizational Debt is Like Technical Debt — But Worse

- [ ]

Work on what matters

Business as usual is over. What was true 2 months ago might be wrong today, and you need to readjust your priorities accordingly. Work on what matters for the business.

Read more:

Work on What Matters

- [ ]

Improve your team's flow

Flow is what makes your team productive, and as an engineering leader, part of your job is to facilitate it.

Read more:

Track and Facilitate Your Engineers' Flow States in This Simple Way

Limiting Work in Progress (WIP)

- [ ]

Prioritize velocity as a metric

But what you do with the metric matters. Use it to open a discussion with every team, to invite them to discuss their pain points and bottlenecks, and to help you determine the initiatives that will benefit the whole organization.

Read more:

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People

During a recession, taking care of your people is critical. As an engineering leader, your ultimate goal should be to build high-performing teams to help you weather the storm.

To achieve this, you must develop empathy and focus on keeping your people happy and aligned with the company's purpose. This will create a recipe for success, allowing your teams to keep improving as your company grows. Let's explore how you can enable this.



Motivate your team

It's likely that your team is stressed by recent company, economy, or political events. Keeping your team motivated is paramount to helping you achieve your goals.

Read more:

How to Motivate a Team of Software Developers

Leadership Through Kindness

Nine Things Developers Want More Than Money

Build a great engineering culture

Just like keeping your teams motivated, building and maintaining a great engineering culture will make you successful once the hiring freeze and recession are over. It's not because there are budget freezes that you shouldn't invest in culture.

Read more:

How to Build an Engineering-First Company Culture

How to Build a Culture of Innovation Every Day

The Developer Culture Test

Learn how to delegate effectively

Delegation is key for an engineering leader. Delegate often and make sure you create clear expectations.

Read more:

How to Delegate Effectively: A Guide for Managers

Effective Delegation: A Key Management Skill

Deal with underperformance

Underperformance needs to be dealt with, especially during a recession where performance is often a matter of survival. You will need to deal with underperformance face-on.

Read more:

Performance Reviews for Software Engineers

How to Help Underperformers

Underperformance of Software Engineers: Causes, Signs, and Solutions

Spend even more time hiring the best people

Hiring in a recession is supposed to be easier as more offer exists in the market. It's not. You can't afford any miss hire if you have the budget for additional headcount.

Read more:

Hiring a Diverse Engineering Team

Engineering Leaders Share Their Biggest Lessons on Hiring

Candidate Experience: A Complete Guide

Focus on retention

Talent retention is going to be key to ensuring high team productivity. The cost of hiring & onboarding new engineers is too high.

Read more:

Building the Civilized Workplace

The Importance of Psychological Safety

Engineering Career Ladders

Create a great remote working culture

Remote can be hard. Especially for first-timers. Make sure you're investing in building a strong remote culture.

Read more:

The Ultimate Guide to Remote Work

Three Essential Remote Work Practices for Engineering

Pay attention to Burnout

You're stressed, and so is your team. Pay extra attention to possible burnout situations.

Read more:

Quantifying Burnout

Have better 1:1s

1–1s are critical to ensure alignment and happiness, learn about the current mindset of your teams, and to

communicate critical news.

Read more:

The One-on-One Meeting: Making Them Productive and Useful

1:1 Basics for the Introvert Engineering Manager

The Team Manager's Toolkit - 1–on-1s

Develop and promote empathy

You need need to empathize with the concerns of executives, customers, and engineers to improve the product's delivery, maximize efficiency and quality, and invest time and resources effectively.

Read more:

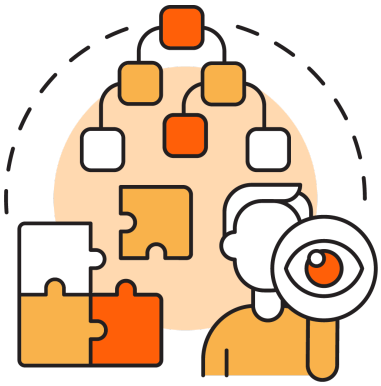
Adapting During Recession: Strategies for Engineering Leaders

Personal

Being a great engineering leader comes from something other than great tools, processes, or even people. It starts with you.

A recession can be stressful, leaving you feeling lost and without a North Star. But to succeed and make it through this time, you must focus on developing yourself as a leader.

The bottom line is: you're not alone. Thousands of leaders in all functions are going through it. So, don't panic, and look into some of the items below for support.



- [ ] ## Write More

Writing will help you increase your communication skills which are crucial as your company faces critical periods.

Read more:

On Writing Well

The Power Business Writing Guide

Everybody Writes

- [ ] ## Operate as an executive first, functional leader second

Your job is to positively impact the business. If you're an executive spending all of your time with the engineering team, you are not doing your job. You need to have regular 1–1s with your peers and need to understand how engineering can have the biggest business impact.

Read more:

Developing an Executive Mindset as an Engineering Leader

- [ ] ## Master the art of decision-making

In these harder times, you need to make sure that you're making the right decisions quickly. It's an art, and you need to improve.

Read more:

6 Decision-Making Frameworks for Engineering Leaders

Eisenhower Matrix: A Guide to Urgent vs. Important

How to Make Smart Decisions: A Simple Guide

Better manage your time

Make sure you proactively control your time. Don't forget to keep time for thinking and reviewing.

Read more:
How to Manage Your Time

Get a mentor

Find an engineering leader who has been in similar situations and can mentor you on a regular basis.

Read more:
PlatoHQ: Learn from the Best Mentors and Coaches in Tech

Software Lead Weekly: Supercharge Your Management Skills

Develop confidence (vs competence)

The level of confidence you portray (especially to stakeholders) is important. This is always true as your team scales, but especially during tough times. "Lead with confidence, show a little bit of competence, and end with confidence again," says Jason Warner (former CTO at Github)

Read more:
Balancing Confidence and Competence

Read more about crises

Relativize the current troubles you're in by reading books about other recessions and crises. They all survived, and so can you!

Read more:
The Return of Depression Economics and the Crisis of 2008

Misbehaving: The Making of Behavioral Economics

A History of the United States in Five Crashes: Stock Market Meltdowns That Defined a Nation

The Smartest Guys in the Room: The Amazing Rise and Scandalous Fall of Enron

Too Big to Fail

Listen to great podcasts

Take advantage of your commute, gym time, or cooking sessions by listening to podcasts, and gain insights from seasoned engineering leaders who are probably sharing their experiences going through similar situations.

Read more:
Developing Leadership

Join helpful communities

Local or online communities are great for connecting with engineering leaders who are going through similar crises. Usually, the more you give, the more you get.

Read more:
New York CTO Club 🇺🇸

Tech.Rocks 🇫🇷

CTO Portugal 🇵🇹

Subscribe to engineering leadership newsletters

Stay on top of the latest engineering best practices and learn from curated newsletters

Read more:
Refactoring

Software Lead Weekly

Level Up Engineering

Broaden your horizons

Learn from other business leaders to explore how different industries operate, strategize, and manage their teams to gain valuable insights.

Read more:
The Score Takes Care of Itself, Bill Walsh

Simple Sabotage Field Guide

How to Win Friends and Influence People, Dale Carnegie

The Ultimate Sales Machine, Chat Holmes

Improve communication with your executives and peers

Communication is a key skill to develop in any period. But miscommunication is certainly very costly during a recession. Make sure you communicate well and often.

Read more:
SCQA: A Powerful Critical Thinking Framework

How to Present to Executives

Managing Upwards

Communicate with Teams: Tips for Leaders

Become a better manager

Improving management skills is crucial for your personal and organizational success. It leads to increased productivity, engagement and reduces employee turnover.

Read more:
People Leave Managers, Not Companies: How to be a Boss People Won't Leave

The 5 Pillars of Successful Engineering Leadership

From IC to Engineering Leader: 3 Essential Lessons

From IC to Engineering Manager: The Skills You Need to Succeed

Improve communication with your executives and peers

Be obsessed with the impact you and your team can create. Instill this to your teams.

Read more:
This is What Impactful Engineering Leadership Looks Like

Technical

Dear engineering leader, it's time to sharpen your axe, the technical axe.

We know you have a ton of tech debt to deal with, which was left unchecked because your teams were too busy focused on hypergrowth. But that's on pause now - you have the gift of time. Use it to do that migration, invest and pamper your CI and hone in on your security.

Here's what we suggest doing on the tech side.



- [ ] ## Invest in and pamper your CI

Now might be a good time to invest in your CI and fix the bottlenecks to make your teams more efficient.

Read more:

An Ideal CI/CD System

6 Strategic Ways to Level Up Your CI/CD Pipeline

Shipping Software Should Not be Scary

- [ ] ## Don't forget about security

Yeah... the recession is keeping you awake at night, but malicious actors haven't stopped. Don't neglect security and implement security best practices early.

Read more:

SaaS CTO Security Checklist

Security Controls Checklist

How Early-Stage Startups Can Enlist the Right Amount of Security as They Grow

- [ ] ## Align on code quality/standards

Let your teams take ownership as you scale and automate as much as possible!

Read more:

How to Choose the Best Code Conventions for You and Your Team

- [ ] ## Fix technical debt

Maybe your company is experiencing a slower growth, and instead of firefighting 🚒 you can invest time and resources into fixing some of the technical debt that is a bottleneck to your success.

Read more:

How to Explain Technical Debt to Executives (Hint: It's Not Technical)

Good and Bad Technical Debt

Technical Debt

Tips on Prioritizing Tech Debt

- [ ]

Default to vendors unless it's your core competency

Recession doesn't mean to start making the wrong decisions and building a bunch of unmaintainable tools internally. Defaulting to vendors should always be the norm.

Read more:

Build vs Buy: Solving the Eternal Software Dilemma

- [ ]

Stay technical

You don't need to know how to debug a bug in the Linux Kernel. But staying technical is important to be able to manage your team or engineering organization.

Read more:

Six Tips for Staying Technical as a CTO

- [ ]

Invest in your technical infrastructure

Crisis mode doesn't mean you should stop improving your system based on your business needs.

Read more:

How to Invest in Technical Infrastructure

- [ ]

Balance quality and speed

Improve your quality only based on your current short/medium-term business needs.

Read more:

Is High Quality Software Worth the Cost?

Managing Technical Quality

- [ ]

Do that migration

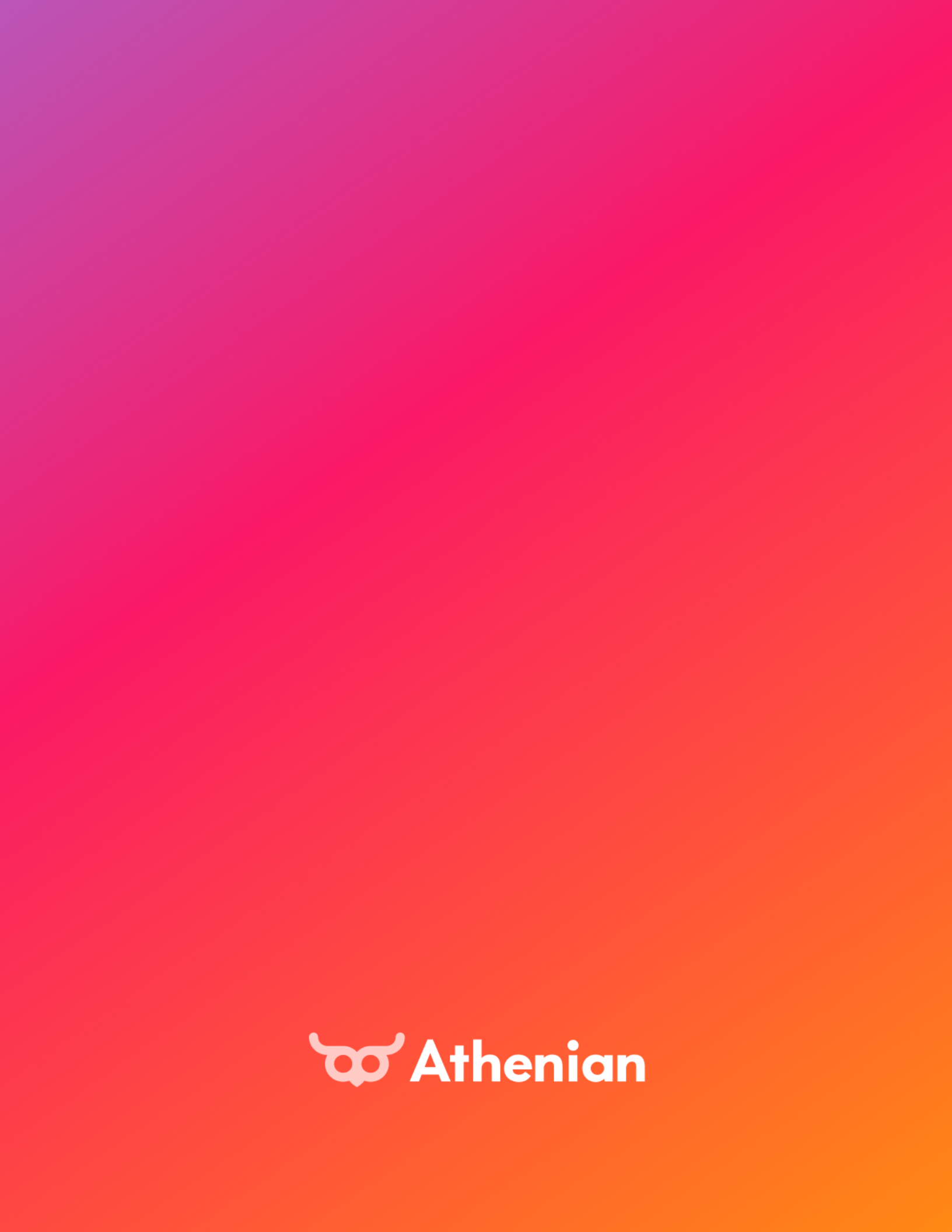
Don't let the recession-mode prevent you from doing that business-critical migration!

Read more:

Migrations: The sole scalable fix to tech debt

Congratulations on making it this far on your journey! 🥳

If you want to learn more about how metrics and data can help you continuously improve and enable your engineering teams, go to athenian.com


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